expressed opposition to Operation Zapata. When Kennedy went round the room, all of them voted for it.

On 15 April 1961 air strikes were launched from Nicaragua to destroy the Cuban air force on three airfields. The CIA estimated that Cuba had some thirty-six combat aircraft, half of which were deemed operational, including six B-26 bombers, six Lockheed T-33 jet trainers, and six British-built piston-engined Hawker Sea Fury fighters.[48] Paratroopers were to be dropped to capture the roads into Playa Giron, denying Castro access while the landings were consolidated. However, the scale of the air strikes had been cut back at presidential insistence, without consulting the Joint Chiefs. Richard Bissell made an arbitrary decision to reduce the first attack from sixteen to eight bombers.

Another B-26 landed in Miami as part of a CIA cover story that the air attacks were conducted by defecting Cuban pilots. It quickly became clear that the plane was a US B-26 (with a metal nose) and not a Cuban B-26 (with a plexiglas nose). Journalists also spotted that its machine guns were taped over (to keep out dirt) and therefore could not have been fired. A second aircraft, which was badly damaged in the attack, made an emergency landing at an airfield in Key West.

The US Ambassador to the UN, Adlai Stevenson, was provided with the cover story by the CIA. In the Political Committee of the UN General Assembly, he denied any US government involvement and brandished a photograph of the B-26 at Miami airport, which ‘has the markings of Castro’s air force on the tail, which everyone can see for himself’.[49] He was, unsurprisingly, furious when the deception was exposed and privately told a friend, ‘There’s nothing I can do but resign. My usefulness and credibility have been totally compromised.’[50] Stevenson subsequently decided that his usefulness and credibility were sufficiently intact to carry on. And in October 1962 he provided one of the iconic moments of the missile crisis when he presented the UN Security Council with some more photographs (this time of Soviet Medium Range Ballistic Missiles in Cuba).

Initial assessments of the B-26 attacks on 15 April 1961 were overly optimistic and suggested the Cuban air force had been effectively destroyed. By the time high-altitude U-2 photography revealed this was not